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Writing women's worlds

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I asked Migdim whether her sons had informed her that they were signing over the land. "No, they didn't come back here. Other people told me they had signed it over....Sagr and Hamid drove the boys away saying, 'I swear to God if one of them opens his mouth I'll drink his blood.' That's what the old one said. They're pimps, the two of them. Ugh!"

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I thought she must be joking. "How can you say that about your sons?"

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Her response was sharp. "They're not my sons. I'm not their mother, nor are they my sons. Sons who crumble what I say and go along with what that woman says? They're not my sons at all."

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Then furiously, almost incoherently, she began to explain what had happened. The problem started with goats. The old man next door had gone to the fathers of the young men of the camp to complain that they had tried to beat up his sons and drive them out. "The old man said they had done this and that and this and that, until Hamid began to act possessed. He started hitting his own sons, shouting at them. He almost killed them. What's this? You beat your own sons for the sake of that woman next door? Our boys had neither hit nor spoken to her boys. All they said was 'You shouldn't let the goats pass through here after grazing.'

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"Nowadays there's an orchard on either side. And when three hundred goats pass through the fig orchards and graze...,they'll eat the figs....There's no open land anymore. But then if we ever want to get some milk from our goats, they [the neighbors] won't let us. We have goats in their herd, you know, but they won't bring them by here so we can milk them. And then the billy goats get loose. I swear I spend the whole day going 'kh, kh, kh, kh' to keep them away. If we put fodder out for the cow, they eat it. If we put fodder out for the donkey, they eat it. If we put water out for the chickens, they drink it. I told my sons to tell them to tie up the goats. Hamid said he would, but he's a liar. I doubt he did."

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